

Rejection Sensitivity and Relationship Satisfaction in Dating Relationships: The Mediating Role of Differentiation of Self

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The present study sought to explore the relationship between rejection sensitivity, differentiation of self, and relationship satisfaction in a sample of emerging adults who were in a dating relationship ($N = 217$, 77.7% female). Results showed that rejection sensitivity was negatively associated with relationship satisfaction. Furthermore, total differentiation of self mediated the relationship between rejection sensitivity and relationship satisfaction. Moreover, in examining the potential mediating effects of the 4 subcomponents of differentiation of self, 1 subcomponent, *emotional cutoff*, also mediated this relationship. Findings suggest that rejection sensitivity might lead individuals to emotionally and behaviorally distance themselves from their romantic partners, thus reducing opportunities for *both* rejecting and accepting experiences, leading to lowered relationship satisfaction. Implications for research and applied work are discussed.

Keywords: rejection sensitivity, relationship satisfaction, differentiation of self, romantic relationships, emerging adulthood

During the unique developmental stage of emerging adulthood, individuals between the ages of 18 and 29 are theorized to explore and experiment within the domains of love, work, and worldviews as they attempt to solidify their identities and beliefs in these areas (Arnett, 2000, 2014). As emerging adults continue developing autonomy from their families of origin, a process that typically begins in adolescence (Collins, Welsh, & Furman, 2009; Grotevant & Cooper, 1998), friendships and romantic relationships become more important during this developmental stage (Arnett, 2014).

As emerging adults navigate romantic relationships in particular, relational schemas about oneself and others often guide romantic experiences (Furman & Wehner, 1997; Smith, Welsh, & Fite, 2010). One relational schema, *rejection*

sensitivity, refers to the tendency to expect, perceive, and overreact to rejection by others (Downey, Bonica, & Rincón, 1999; Downey & Feldman, 1996; Downey, Lebolt, Rincón, & Freitas, 1998). Theoretically, this relational schema develops early on in children who were raised by caregivers that failed to meet their needs for safety and security (Bowlby, 1973). For protection, these children become hypervigilant and readily expect rejecting behaviors. These expectations and increased perceptions of rejection cue them to overreact in an effort to gain the attention and security of their caregivers (Bowlby, 1973; Downey & Feldman, 1996).

Rejection Sensitivity and Relationship Satisfaction in Dating Relationships

Over time, rejection sensitivity is carried into adolescence and adulthood and affects interactions between romantic partners (Downey & Feldman, 1996). In experimental and observational research on adolescent and emerging adult dating couples, higher rejection sensitivity has been found to predict relationship processes and outcomes. In particular, individuals who are sensitive to rejection also tend to report low satisfaction in their dating relationships (Downey & Feldman, 1996, 2004; Galliher &

This article was published Online First April 11, 2016.
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We gratefully acknowledge Dr. Jennifer Bolden for her assistance with the Institutional Review Board procedures for this study.

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Bentley, 2010). According to Downey and Feldman (1996, 2004), individuals who are highly sensitive to rejection tend to perceive their romantic partners' ambiguous or neutral behaviors as rejecting, thus coloring their perceptions of their romantic experiences and reducing their relationship satisfaction. This contention has been corroborated with both observational (Galliher & Bentley, 2010) and self-report (Downey & Feldman, 1996) data, showing that the link between rejection sensitivity and relationship satisfaction is mediated by the overestimation of rejection by romantic partners.

Although rejection sensitivity and its link with relationship satisfaction in dating couples has been empirically established, it is possible that other variables might play mediating roles in this relationship. In particular, as emerging adults strive to achieve their developmental tasks through dating relationships (Arnett, 2000, 2014; Shulman & Connolly, 2013), taking a developmental lens in the examination of rejection sensitivity and relationship satisfaction might help deepen current understandings of emerging adult dating relationships.

Differentiation of Self in Emerging Adulthood

Differentiation of self, a concept rooted in Bowen's (1978) theory of family systems, has received relatively less empirical attention with emerging adult dating couples. To our knowledge, only one study has empirically examined this construct in a sample of dating individuals (Khaddouma, Gordon, & Bolden, 2015). The process of differentiation of self theoretically begins in childhood and involves achieving a healthy balance of independence and interdependence with important others in one's life. This includes separating one's own thoughts and feelings from that of others and intentionally acting according to one's own thoughts and desires, all while maintaining intimacy with others (Bowen, 1978; Skowron & Friedlander, 1998).

It is our contention that this journey of maintaining a balance of independence and interdependence is integral to emerging adults' romantic exploration. Specifically, according to theory on emerging adulthood, young people are expected to maintain their independence while

simultaneously exploring and establishing meaningful romantic relationships (Arnett, 2000, 2014). Establishing independence involves attaining an identity that is separate from one's family of origin, friends, and romantic partners, having a sense of purpose that is independent of important others, and having a core set of values that guide decisions and actions (Arnett, 2014). Additionally, establishing independence involves the ability to act autonomously through thinking, deciding, and taking action based on one's own volition (Van Petegem, Vansteenkiste, & Beyers, 2013). Given the overlap between differentiation of self and some of the primary developmental tasks that emerging adults face, differentiation of self could be an important variable to examine within the context of emerging adults' romantic experiences.

Differentiation of self includes four subcomponents (Skowron & Friedlander, 1998). Specifically, *emotional reactivity* refers to the inability to regulate emotions in the face of others' emotional expressions; *emotional cutoff* refers to the tendency to distance oneself from others to appear independent; *I-position* refers to the ability to maintain one's identity and sense of self independent of others' pressure to behave, think, or feel otherwise; and *fusion with others* refers to one's high interdependence with one's family of origin and a desire to gain their acceptance and approval (Skowron & Friedlander, 1998). Indeed, Bowenian theory posits that individuals with less differentiation of self may struggle to balance cognitive, emotional, and relational independence and interdependence (Bowen, 1978).

As noted previously, differentiation of self has received relatively less empirical attention in the context of dating relationships. However, given the overlap between the concepts of differentiation of self and emerging adults' core developmental tasks, it is possible that differentiation of self plays an important role in young people's romantic experiences, and ultimately, their satisfaction in romantic relationships. Indeed, differentiation of self has been found to predict relationship satisfaction for married individuals (Parsons, Nalbone, Killmer, & Wetchler, 2007; Peleg, 2008). As dating relationships are common in emerging adulthood (Shulman & Connolly, 2013), the exploration of differentiation of self and its links with relationship

satisfaction is warranted for this particular population.

Rejection Sensitivity, Differentiation of Self, and Relationship Satisfaction

Rejection sensitivity and differentiation of self might work together to predict relationship satisfaction for emerging adult dating couples. Avoiding rejection and acquiring acceptance from important others both provide security in one's identity (Hart, Shaver, & Goldenberg, 2005). Those who are sensitive to rejection might be more vulnerable to others' opinions about their identities, contributing to difficulties differentiating between their own and others' opinions. Unfortunately, research on rejection sensitivity and differentiation of self (and related concepts) is scarce. Existing research has shown that rejection sensitivity is linked to one's confidence in and sense of stability about one's identity. In a cross-sectional study, rejection sensitivity was found to be related to a balance of independence and interdependence in social relationships, which is closely related to the concept of differentiation (Wismeijer, van Assen, & Bekker, 2014). A longitudinal study found that for highly rejection-sensitive individuals, confidence in and sense of stability about their identity tend to erode after experiencing rejection (Ayduk, Gyurak, & Luerssen, 2009). Additionally, a longitudinal daily diary study found that rejection sensitivity was related to the ways individuals reacted to situations in which they depended on (i.e., had little control over an interpersonal situation) a family member (Overall & Sibley, 2009). Such findings provide evidence for the importance of one's sense of self for those who are sensitive to rejection.

As both rejection sensitivity and differentiation of self theoretically originate in childhood, it is important to examine the possible bidirectional relationship between these two variables. In other words, rather than rejection sensitivity predicting differentiation of self, differentiation of self might predict rejection sensitivity. It is possible that a lack of differentiation from important others leads one to become more vulnerable in the face of rejection and grow to expect and perceive rejection in neutral situations. Unfortunately, no studies to date have examined the longitudinal relationship between

differentiation of self (or related concepts such as identity, independence, or interdependence) or rejection.

Proposing a Mediation Model

Given the theoretical and empirical link between rejection sensitivity and one's sense of self, it is possible that one's level of differentiation from others might account for the relationship between rejection sensitivity and relationship satisfaction. For example, an individual who is highly sensitive to rejection might be less satisfied in a romantic relationship because he or she is highly undifferentiated from his or her romantic partner. Specifically, the individual might have difficulty regulating emotions, maintaining an independent sense of self, or is highly emotionally and/or behaviorally fused with a romantic partner. These challenges might further color romantic experiences for the rejection-sensitive individual, reducing his or her relationship satisfaction. Relatedly, it is possible that rejection sensitivity might account for the relationship between differentiation of self and relationship satisfaction. An individual who is relatively undifferentiated from his or her romantic partner might be particularly hypervigilant of and attuned to rejection, thus observing much rejection during their interactions and reducing his or her relationship satisfaction. To clarify these potential bidirectional relationships, various mediational models will be tested in the present study.

The Present Study

The purpose of the present study is to explore the potential mediating role of differentiation of self in the relationship between rejection sensitivity and relationship satisfaction. As existing longitudinal research (Overall & Sibley, 2009; Wismeijer et al., 2014) suggests that rejection sensitivity influences concepts related to differentiation of self, rejection sensitivity is first tested as the independent variable and differentiation of self as the mediator. However, this hypothesized model will be tested via multiple mediation models to determine the direction of influence across rejection sensitivity and differentiation of self. Our specific hypotheses are as follows:

Hypothesis 1: Rejection sensitivity will be negatively related to relationship satisfaction.

Hypothesis 2: Total differentiation of self will mediate the relationship between rejection sensitivity and relationship satisfaction.

Additionally, to further clarify the potential mediating roles of the different subcomponents of differentiation of self, the present study also aims to conduct exploratory analyses on the four subcomponents within a mediating model. These four subcomponents include lowered abilities to: regulate emotions (emotional reactivity), maintain an independent sense of self (I-position), avoid distancing oneself emotionally and behaviorally from partners (emotional cutoff), and maintain a balance of separateness from and closeness with others (fusion with others).

Method

Participants

A total of 251 undergraduate students from a Southeastern university in the United States participated in the present study. Participants were recruited from introductory level psychology courses, which required participation in research, through a widely used participant recruitment tool called SONA systems. Participants were given course credit in exchange for participation. Eligible individuals must be between the ages of 18 and 29 years old and must be involved in an exclusive romantic relationship for a minimum of three weeks.

Missing data were accounted for by listwise deletion; 34 individuals who did not complete any of the measures of interests were not included in the final sample. The final sample included 217 participants. The majority of participants were female (77.7%), heterosexual (95.6%), and not currently living with their romantic partner (96.8%). Participants primarily identified as White/Caucasian (86.0%), as well as African American (4.4%), Asian American (4.0%), Hispanic/Latino (2.4%), Native Hawaiian/Pacific Islander (0.8%), multiracial (1.2%), and "other" (1.2%). The majority of participants were freshmen (77.7%), followed by sophomores (12.4%), juniors (6.4%), and seniors

(3.6%). On average, participants were 18.64 years old ($SD = 1.35$, range = 18–27) and the average length of their current romantic relationship was 13.93 months ($SD = 13.78$, range = 1 month to 69 months).

Measures

Rejection sensitivity. The Rejection Sensitivity Questionnaire (RSQ; Downey & Feldman, 1996) includes 18 situations that assess rejection anxiety (e.g., *How concerned or anxious would you be over whether or not your boyfriend would want to see you?*) and rejection expectations (e.g., *I would expect that he would want to see me*). For each situation, respondents rate on a 6-point scale their level of anxiety about the outcome of each situation (1 = *unconcerned*; 6 = *very concerned*) and the likelihood that the other person(s) would respond in a compliant manner (1 = *very unlikely*; 6 = *very likely*). Scores are summed and divided by 18 to yield the total rejection sensitivity score. Good internal consistency was observed in the development of the measure ($\alpha = .83$; Downey & Feldman, Study 1). The RSQ was also found to be valid, as demonstrated by its relationships with perceived hostility and criticism from others, personality variables, attachment style, and social anxiety (Downey & Feldman, Studies 2 and 3). High internal consistency was observed in the present sample ($\alpha = .86$).

Differentiation of self. The revised version of the Differentiation of Self Inventory (DSI-R; Skowron & Schmitt, 2003) is a 46-item, self-report questionnaire that assesses one's level of healthy differentiation from important others. Although the original measure was designed for individuals 25 years and above, it has been used with samples of emerging adults (Khaddouma et al., 2015). This questionnaire is based on Bowen's family systems model of relationships. The DSI-R consists of four subscales, including emotional reactivity, I-position, emotional cutoff, and fusion with others, which each assess the specific components of differentiation of self. Respondents rate on a 6-point scale the degree to which a statement applies to them (1 = *not at all true of me*; 6 = *very true of me*). Example items include *People have remarked that I'm overly emotional* and *I tend to distance myself when people get too close to me*. After appropriate items are reversed scored (see

Skowron & Schmitt, 2003), item scores for each subcomponent are averaged. The subscale scores and the overall differentiation score ranges from 1 to 6; higher scores indicate higher levels of each subcomponent of differentiation (i.e., less emotional reactivity, emotional cutoff, and fusion with others, and greater ability to take I-positions in relationships). Good reliability has been observed in previous samples, from .88 to .90, as well as strong relationships with emotion regulation and adjustment (Skowron, 2000; Skowron & Schmitt, 2003; Skowron, Wester, & Azen, 2004). Internal consistency for the overall measure in the current sample was high ($\alpha = .80$). Internal consistencies for the individual subscales were as follows: emotional reactivity, $\alpha = .66$; I position, $\alpha = .71$; emotional cutoff, $\alpha = .66$; and fusion with others, $\alpha = .61$.

Relationship satisfaction. The Couple Satisfaction Index (CSI; Funk & Rogge, 2007) is a 16-item, self-report questionnaire that assesses relationship satisfaction. Respondents indicate the degree to which various statements apply to them and/or their relationship. Example items include *Our relationship is strong* and *My relationship with my partner makes me happy* to which participants respond on a 6-point scale (0 = *not at all true*; 5 = *completely true*). Scores are calculated using the sum of all items, with higher scores indicating greater relationship satisfaction. Original internal consistency was high ($\alpha = .98$; Funk & Rogge, 2007) and the measure demonstrated relationships with previously developed measures of relationship satisfaction (Graham, Diebels, & Barnow, 2011). Internal consistency in the current sample was high ($\alpha = .96$).

Procedure

Participants completed the measures through a widely used online survey system (Qualtrics.com). The informed consent form was provided through the survey system prior to the presentation of the online measures. Participants who provided their informed consent were directed to the online measures. Participants were given course credit in exchange for their participation to fulfill course requirements for their introductory psychology courses.

Results

Bivariate Correlations and Descriptive Statistics

Analyses were conducted with SPSS Version 21.0. Means, standard deviations, ranges of scores, and correlations among variables are provided in Table 1. Bivariate correlations showed that relationship satisfaction was negatively associated with rejection sensitivity. Relationship satisfaction was also positively associated with the total differentiation of self score, as well as each of the subcomponents of emotional reactivity, I-position, emotional cutoff, and fusion with others. Rejection sensitivity was also negatively associated with the total differentiation of self score, as well as each of the subcomponents of emotional reactivity, I-position, emotional cutoff, and fusion with others. Neither age, gender, race/ethnicity, living situation, nor relationship length were significantly related to the outcome variable, and thus were not controlled for the in present analyses.

Table 1
Means, Standard Deviations, and Bivariate Correlations Among Variables

Variable	1	2	3	4	5	6	7
1. Rejection sensitivity	—	-.19**	-.27**	-.22**	-.18**	-.22**	-.14*
2. Relationship satisfaction		—	.35**	.17*	.21**	.42**	.17*
3. Differentiation of self			—	.80**	.76**	.56**	.75**
Emotional reactivity				—	.55**	.12	.67**
I-position					—	.17**	.50**
Emotional cutoff						—	.118
Fusion with others							—
<i>M</i>	15.36	29.48	3.24	3.77	2.85	2.90	3.89
<i>SD</i>	5.16	12.70	.50	.69	.66	.70	.69
Range	1–36	0–81	1–6	1–6	1–6	1–6	1–6

* $p < .05$. ** $p < .01$.

To examine the relationship between rejection sensitivity and relationship satisfaction with the mediators of total differentiation of self (Model 1) and the individual subcomponents of differentiation of self (Model 2), we utilized Preacher and Hayes's (2008) bootstrapping method for testing multiple mediator models via the PROCESS macro in SPSS. With moderate sample sizes, such as that of the present study, bootstrapping has been found to be the most appropriate strategy to test multiple mediator models (Briggs, 2006; Williams & MacKinnon, 2008). Bootstrapping resampling provides a more accurate estimate of indirect effects compared to Sobel tests (Sobel, 1986) of mediation (MacKinnon, Lockwood, & Williams, 2004; Shrout & Bolger, 2002). As suggested by Preacher and Hayes (2008), 5,000 random resamples from the present sample were taken to calculate the total and indirect effects, as well as confidence intervals for each path. Results of the analyses are presented in Table 2.

Does Differentiation of Self Mediate the Relationship Between Rejection Sensitivity and Relationship Satisfaction?

First, we examined the relationship between rejection sensitivity and relationship satisfaction (Hypothesis 1) with the total differentiation of self score as a mediator (Hypothesis 2). Bootstrapping analyses indicated that the total effect of rejection sensitivity on relationship satisfaction, independent of the proposed mediating variable, was significant ($c = -.4209, p = .01$). When the total differentiation of self score was included in the model as a mediator, the total effect became nonsignificant ($c' = -.2048, p = .21$). Thus, when total differentiation of self is controlled for, rejection sensitivity is not significantly related to relationship satisfaction, indicating that differentiation of self mediates this relationship. Examining the individual indirect effect, total differentiation of self was significant ($a_1b_1 = -.2161, 95\% \text{ CI} = [-.3856, -.1026]$)¹.

To test an alternative model of mediation, the above analyses were conducted with differentiation of self as the predictor variable and rejection sensitivity as the mediator. Given the cross-sectional nature of the present study and the theoretical assertion that both constructs originate in early childhood, this alternative model

was tested to determine the direction of influence. Bootstrapping results indicated a nonsignificant mediation model with differentiation of self as the predictor variable and rejection sensitivity as the mediator ($a_1b_1 = .6022, 95\% \text{ CI} = [-.2256, 1.4955]$). Thus, results did not support a mediation model in which differentiation of self was the predictor variable and rejection sensitivity was the mediator.

Do the Subcomponents of Differentiation of Self Mediate the Relationship Between Rejection Sensitivity and Relationship Satisfaction?

Second, we examined how the four subcomponents of differentiation of self might mediate the relationship between rejection sensitivity and relationship satisfaction. Bootstrapping analyses were repeated with the four subcomponents of differentiation of self to determine how their potential mediating role. When these variables were included in the model as mediators, the total effect became nonsignificant ($c' = -.1582, p = .3201$). Thus, when the subcomponents of differentiation of self are controlled for, rejection sensitivity is not significantly related to relationship satisfaction, indicating that these subcomponents mediate this relationship. The total indirect effect with all mediators in the model was significant ($a_1b_1 + a_2b_2 + a_3b_3 + a_4b_4 = -.2627, 95\% \text{ CI} = [-.4568, -.1217]$). In examining the specific individual indirect effects, the subcomponent *emotional cutoff* was significant ($a_3b_3 = -.1808, 95\% \text{ CI} = [-.3494, -.0531]$). However, *emotional reactivity*, *I-position*, and *fusion with others* were not significant (see Figure 1).

To test an alternative model of mediation, the above analyses were conducted with the subcomponent *emotional cutoff* as the predictor variable and rejection sensitivity as the mediator. Only *emotional cutoff* was explored in an alternative model because of its significance in the previous analysis. Bootstrapping results indicated a nonsignificant mediation model with *emotional cutoff* as a predictor variable and rejection sensitivity as the mediator ($a_1b_1 = .3798, 95\% \text{ CI} = [-.1090,$

¹ The effect is significant when the lower and upper ranges of the 95% CI do not include zero (Preacher & Hayes, 2008).

Table 2

Mediation Model of the Effects of Rejection Sensitivity on Relationship Satisfaction Through Differentiation of Self and Its Subcomponents

Variable	Point estimate	Product of coefficients			Bootstrapping					
		SE	Z	p	Percentile 95% CI		BC 95% CI		BCa 95% CI	
					Lower	Upper	Lower	Upper	Lower	Upper
Differentiation of self (total)	-.2161	.0679	-3.1807	.00	-.3678	-.0960	-.3856	-.1022	-.3856	-.1026
Differentiation of self (subcomponents)	-.2627	.0819	-3.2065	.00	-.4484	-.1161	-.4547	-.1206	-.4568	-.1217
Emotional reactivity	-.0287	.0521	-.5507	.5818	-.1384	.0523	-.1480	.0463	-.1527	.0452
I-position	-.0377	.0375	-1.0052	.3148	-.1259	.0317	-.1379	.0233	-.1353	.0243
Emotional cutoff	-.1808	.0668	-2.7051	.0068	-.3451	-.0511	-.3546	-.0562	-.3494	-.0531
Fusion with others	-.0156	.0271	-.5745	.5656	-.0847	.0383	-.1059	.0252	-.1043	.0254

Note. BC = bias corrected; BCa = bias corrected and accelerated; 5,000 bootstrap samples.

.8871]). Thus, results did not support a mediation model in which *emotional cutoff* was the predictor variable and rejection sensitivity was the mediator.

Discussion

Rejection Sensitivity and Relationship Satisfaction

Differentiation of self as a mediator. The present study sought to explore the relationship between rejection sensitivity and relationship sat-

isfaction and the potential mediating role of differentiation of self, as well as the potential mediating roles of the four subcomponents of differentiation of self. First, consistent with previous research (Downey & Feldman, 1996; Galliher & Bentley, 2010), we found that rejection sensitivity was negatively associated with relationship satisfaction. Importantly, one's total level of differentiation significantly mediated this relationship. These results suggest that rejection sensitivity indirectly predicts relationship satisfaction through one's ability to establish emotional and

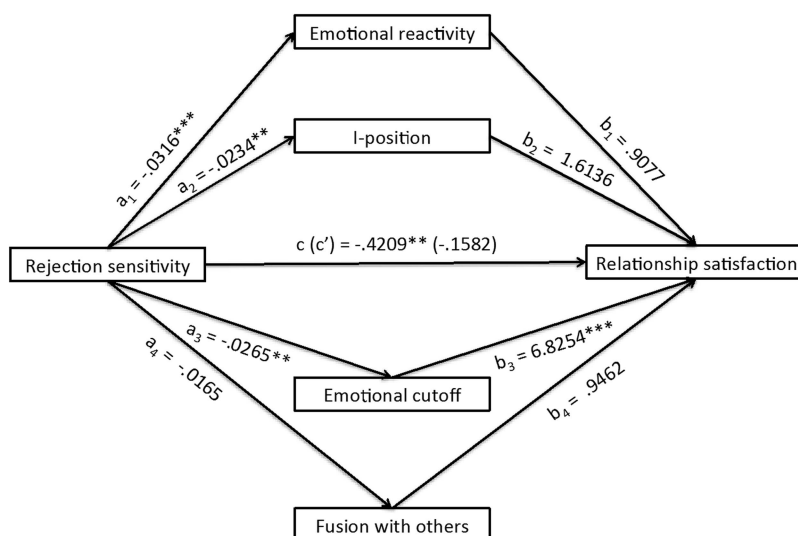


Figure 1. The relationship between rejection sensitivity and relationship satisfaction mediated by the four subcomponents of differentiation of self with corresponding coefficients. ** $p < .01$. *** $p < .001$.

behavioral separateness from important others. Thus, the present findings extend our existing knowledge about the variables through which rejection sensitivity predicts relationship satisfaction and point to differentiation of self as one such mechanism.

Subcomponents of differentiation of self as mediators. In further examining the specific mechanisms through which rejection sensitivity predicts relationship satisfaction, we also examined the four subcomponents of differentiation of self, which include *emotional reactivity*, *I-position*, *emotional cutoff*, and *fusion with others*. Results showed that rejection sensitivity indirectly predicted relationship satisfaction through *emotional cutoff*, which refers to the tendency to distance oneself from important others due to fears of intimacy and closeness. These results indicate that higher rejection sensitivity might lead to the development of emotional distancing from one's romantic partner. This distance might result in fewer opportunities for engaging in shared activities or other intimate acts, further leading the individual to find his or her relationship unsatisfactory. In other words, greater sensitivity to rejection might lead an individual to become emotionally distant from one's romantic partner, and this emotional distance might reduce one's satisfaction in the romantic relationship.

Drawing from early developmental literature, rejection sensitivity originally serves as a protective mechanism to help individuals acquire safety and security from others (Downey et al., 1998; Downey & Feldman, 1996). Theoretically, children develop rejection sensitivity to readily expect hostility and criticism from caretakers in order to avoid additional situations in which their safety might be threatened (Downey & Feldman, 1996). In emerging adulthood, it is possible that when highly rejection-sensitive individuals overperceive rejecting behaviors from their partners, they might react by emotionally distancing oneself from romantic partners to reduce the rejection they experience. This finding is consistent with previous research that indicates that individuals who are highly sensitive to rejection tend to engage in self-silencing behaviors, whereby they purposely withhold expressing their needs or desires in order to preserve their relationship (Harper, Dickson, & Welsh, 2006). Indeed, increasing emotional dis-

tance can also include increasing physical distance, such as choosing not to spend time with a romantic partner. If the rejection-sensitive individual does interact with his or her romantic partner, these interactions might be very brief (Kerr, 1980), with limited self-disclosure, participation in shared activities, or sexual activity that make the individual vulnerable to further rejection.

Unfortunately, emotional and physical distancing has its consequences. Although individuals are attempting to reduce the potential for rejection, distance also reduces the potential for fulfilling, accepting, and intimate behaviors. As young people pursue romantic relationships to fulfill their needs for interdependence (Arnett, 2014; Collins & Steinberg, 2006), the possible tendency for rejection-sensitive individuals in the present sample to distance themselves from their partner and reducing both potentially rejecting and accepting experiences might in turn reduce their satisfaction in the relationship.

Implications of the Present Study

The finding that emotional cutoff mediates the link between rejection sensitivity and relationship satisfaction has important implications. First, for professionals who work with young people in dating relationships who are sensitive to rejection, it might be particularly helpful for such individuals to become aware of emotionally distancing behaviors that might hinder their ability to have intimate and satisfying romantic relationships. Although the concept of differentiation is generally a lifelong process (Bowen, 1978), the awareness of the emotions and behaviors that are related to rejection sensitivity, as well as how they influence individual and couple outcomes, is an important step in young people's romantic journeys. Second, findings from the present study extend existing knowledge of the coping strategies that rejection-sensitive individuals might use to gain control over their romantic partners. Previously, Downey et al. (1999) highlighted *coercion* and *compliance* as primary reactions to rejection. Coercion involves verbally and/or physically aggressive acts meant to force romantic partners to remain in the relationship. Similarly, compliance involves giving in to one's romantic partner's potentially harmful or unhealthy demands

to prevent further rejection (Downey et al., 1999). Both of these strategies involve psychologically moving toward a romantic partner; however, *emotional cutoff* adds a different dimension to this repertoire of reactions, as it uniquely involves establishing both emotional and physical distance.

The majority of participants were in their freshman year, and it is possible that this time of transitioning into college could play a role in the present findings. As new college students generally transition from their parents' homes into college housing, and their peers become more salient figures than members of their family of origin (Arnett, 2014), college students have novel opportunities to meet people from different backgrounds and with diverse opinions (Bryant, 2003). These novel experiences for college students and their romantic partners might make the possibility for conflictual interactions and the perception of rejection more salient. Additionally, as college students search for a balance of independence and interdependence during emerging adulthood (Arnett, 2014), it might be difficult for them to navigate the transition out of their parents' homes and into a social environment filled with peers and romantic partners. It might be helpful for mental health professionals who work with college students to focus on the process of differentiation in this unique transitional period to aid young people in their lifelong process toward balancing their needs with that of romantic partners. Specifically, for individuals who tend to be sensitive to rejection, practitioners can increase college students' awareness of the particular difficulty of this developmental period and help them regulate their reactivity when faced with perceived rejection from romantic partners. As college students, and freshmen in particular, have more time in college and later in life to gain a healthy level of differentiation, it is possible that their ability to regulate their emotions in reaction to partners' perceived rejection might develop over time.

Limitations of the Study and Directions for Future Research

Several limitations are important to note. First, as the present study was cross-sectional in nature, we cannot be certain of the direction of cause between the variables. However, the the-

oretical assertion that rejection sensitivity originates in childhood (Downey & Feldman, 1996) adds confidence to the present findings. Second, the variables in the present study were assessed via self-report measures. Future studies might consider the use of observational methods, which might be particularly helpful in further examining emotional cutoff behaviors. Relatedly, the internal consistencies for various sub-components of differentiation of self were below the acceptable range of .70, thus increasing the probability of a Type II error. It is possible that the nonsignificant results found here stem from this inflation. It is important to note that some research using college student samples shows internal consistencies less than .70 (Gushue et al., 2013; Khaddouma et al., 2015; Skowron & Platt, 2005). Third, the majority of individuals in the present study identified as female, White, heterosexual, and in their freshman year of college; thus, the generalizability to other populations, particularly the entire population of emerging adults, is limited. Future studies might explore the relationships among rejection sensitivity, differentiation of self, and relationship satisfaction in a more diverse sample, particularly ones that include individuals from various races/ethnicities and sexual orientations. Importantly, as the majority of participants were female college students, future studies should include a more equalized number of young women and men who have attended and have not attended college. Additionally, future studies might explore the particular developmental period of transitioning into college and how this time might be related to college students' interpersonal relationships. Importantly, this study was limited in its exclusion of emerging adults who are not college students. To determine whether the present findings apply to all individuals in this developmental period, researchers are encouraged to include both college students and noncollege students in their investigations.

Furthermore, the present findings should be interpreted with caution, as over 75% of participants were females. Some research indicates that young women tend to react to rejection differently compared to boys and young men (Downey et al., 1999). As young men might react to rejection with jealous behaviors (e.g., monitoring whereabouts), and young women might react with unsupportive behaviors (e.g.,

lack of affection, lack of attention to sexual needs), further research is necessary to determine the mechanisms through which rejection sensitivity predicts relationship satisfaction. Additionally, however, other research indicates that men respond to conflict with romantic partners by withdrawing emotionally (Gottman, 1994; Heavey, Layne, & Christensen, 1993), which is consistent with the differentiation of self subcomponent *emotional cutoff*. Further research on women's and men's reactions to rejection in conflict might clarify these findings and add clarity to the interpretation of the present study's findings.

Finally, only one couple member from the romantic relationship participated in the present study, thus limiting our view into the romantic relationship. Given that rejection sensitivity has been found to negatively predict relationship satisfaction for *both* couple members (Downey & Feldman, 1996; Galliher & Bentley, 2010), a promising area for future research involves examining these variables in both couple members. Despite these limitations, the present study extends previous work by providing evidence that differentiation of self, and in particular, emotional cutoff, mediates the relationship between rejection sensitivity and relationship satisfaction.

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- Received August 16, 2015
Revision received January 19, 2016
Accepted February 23, 2016 ■

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